have gambled on sending nuclear missiles to Cuba? And had Khrushchev gambled on sending nuclear missiles to Cuba, would President Nixon have held back from destroying the missiles? What if the Soviets had openly declared their intention to send missiles to Cuba, as Castro wanted and as the US had done in Europe? What if Khrushchev had ordered his surface ships to run the naval blockade and resist the US navy (and meant what he said)? What if, with armed conflict imminent, the Presidium had decided to force Khrushchev from office and announce a retreat? What if, when Captain Savitsky fired his nuclear torpedo, it failed to detonate? Such questions can be helpful in assessing the risk of nuclear war. At the same they are essentially unanswerable, even if historians still need to make the effort.

If Captain Savitsky (or Captain Shumkov) had fired his T-5 torpedo at an US warship (and the warhead detonated), other US warships would have almost certainly and immediately acted in self-defence or anticipatory self-defence. Whether that might have involved nuclear depth charges depends on a host of operational factors. What if Gribkov's 'enterprising Soviet commander' had launched a nuclear missile at Guantánamo Bay? If President Kennedy had retaliated with nuclear weapons, would a regional nuclear war have remained regional? We cannot predict the past (though McNamara was certain Kennedy would have reacted with nuclear weapons against Soviet MRBM strikes). Yet, however we travel from the Bermuda Triangle (or the North Pole or a forest near Guantánamo) to Armageddon, the use of strategic nuclear weapons against the homeland of the adversary is a necessary part of the journey. Without a substantial strategic nuclear exchange, the prospect of a 'Nuclear Winter' receded into the twilight, where 'only' hundreds and thousands of innocent people would have died (a sentence best read with the voice of General Turgidson in mind).

Everything we have learned about how Kennedy and Khrushchev sought to resolve the crisis by diplomacy underlines their determination to avoid war. Yet, at times, their actions spoke at least as loudly as their words. Kennedy imposed a naval blockade around Cuba that envisaged attacks on Soviet warships in certain circumstances. He set in motion the largest mobilisation of nuclear forces ever seen (before or since). Khrushchev not